Brigade (3 JAK Rif). In the absence of Brigadier Gurbax Singh, or any brigade staff for that matter, there was no one present who could effectively take control of the situation. Had some elements of Brigade HQ been present, the logical thing to do would have been to locate 1 Madras, pull them into the town with 3 JAK Rif and then recapture the 1 Sikh LI defences that were now held by a motely group of Chinese troops. With every passing hour, without an Indian counter-attack, the Chinese were being allowed to consolidate their scattered forces who had been probing towards Bomdila.

In the post-war analysis of events, some effort seems to have been made to paint a picture that does not quite add up. Just as Dirang Dzong folded without a semblance of a fight, 48 Brigade, despite holding a very strong hand, simply threw away a chance to give the Chinese forces a bloody nose. Not only did the brigade collapse in the most shameful manner, by making tall claims of Chinese attacks on Bomdila during the afternoon of 18 November, a smokescreen has been thrown up in an effort to obfuscate the truth. As a part of this myth, it was made to look as if 1 Madras was locked in a grim struggle with the Chinese, from which it subsequently broke contact under the cover of darkness and ‘withdrew’.

In actuality, all efforts by 1 Madras to establish contact with 48 Brigade HQ had failed simply because the entire brigade staff had virtually abandoned its station the moment the Chinese had been sighted at Bomdila. A probing patrol led by a JCO reported back to Lieutenant Colonel K. K. Chandran that there was no activity in the Brigade HQ. Chandran then realized that the brigade must have withdrawn from Bomdila, leaving them to face the Chinese on their own. Though the Madras officers were completely unfamiliar with the terrain around them, it was decided to extricate the battalion by following the ridge running eastwards to Nafra and then try and head for Kaspi, all points of reference picked off the map. By 11 p.m., the last of the sub-units had also pulled out of their defences. However, as soon as it started moving, the battalion completely lost its bearings and spent that night and the next day wandering around in the jungles. Even at this stage, 1 Madras was relatively untouched and still existed as a cohesive fighting force.

After nightfall, Major Rawat, the brigade major of 48 Brigade along with Major Shashi Dang and Captain Lakhan Pal of 67 Brigade made their way back to Bomdila. Rawat’s main objective was to recover some